

Multi-Engine Giants and Seaplanes

Lack of firm, smooth runways made seaplanes popular; they could be landed almost anywhere, provided the seas were calm. Designers, especially Sikorsky in Russia, had already conceived luxury airliners with insulated, heated cabins. World War I brought the need for heavy bombers, which led to vast aircraft with up to six engines, flying at high altitude for hundreds of miles to drop tons of bombs on enemy cities.



△ Benoist XIV 1913

Origin US

Engine 75 hp Roberts water-cooled 6-cylinder in-line

Top speed 64 mph (103 km/h)

The world's first heavier-than-air airline service used two of these small Benoist XIV seaplanes, which flew over Tampa Bay in Florida. The venture was not a commercial success.

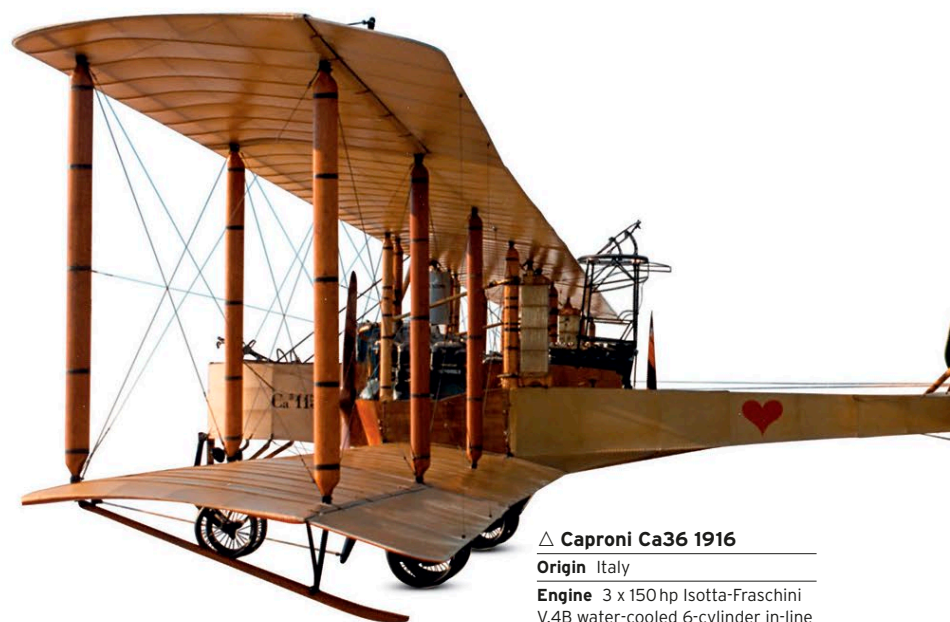
▷ Sikorsky S22 "Ilya Murometz" 1913

Origin Russia

Engine 4 x 100 hp Argus water-cooled 4-cylinder in-line

Top speed 68 mph (109 km/h)

Igor Sikorsky had designed the first four-engine aircraft; he built this as a luxury airliner with heating and toilet, but swiftly redesigned it as the first heavy bomber. Of 73 built, only one was shot down.



△ Caproni Ca36 1916

Origin Italy

Engine 3 x 150 hp Isotta-Fraschini V.4B water-cooled 6-cylinder in-line

Top speed 85 mph (137 km/h)

Armed with two machine guns and able to carry 1,764 lb (800 kg) of bombs, the Ca36 was a potent heavy bomber from the final years of WWI, operated by the Italian Army and Air Force; 153 were built.



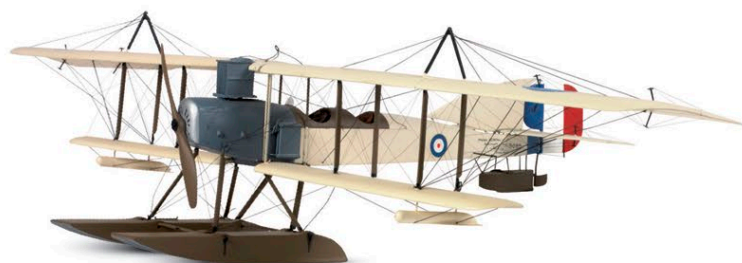
△ Caudron G.4 1915

Origin France

Engine 2 x 80 hp Le Rhône 9C air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 77 mph (124 km/h)

Caudron enlarged the G.3 and fitted twin engines to turn it into a practical bomber. It carried 220 lb (100 kg) of bombs into the heart of Germany in WWI, often at night, although it soon suffered heavy losses.



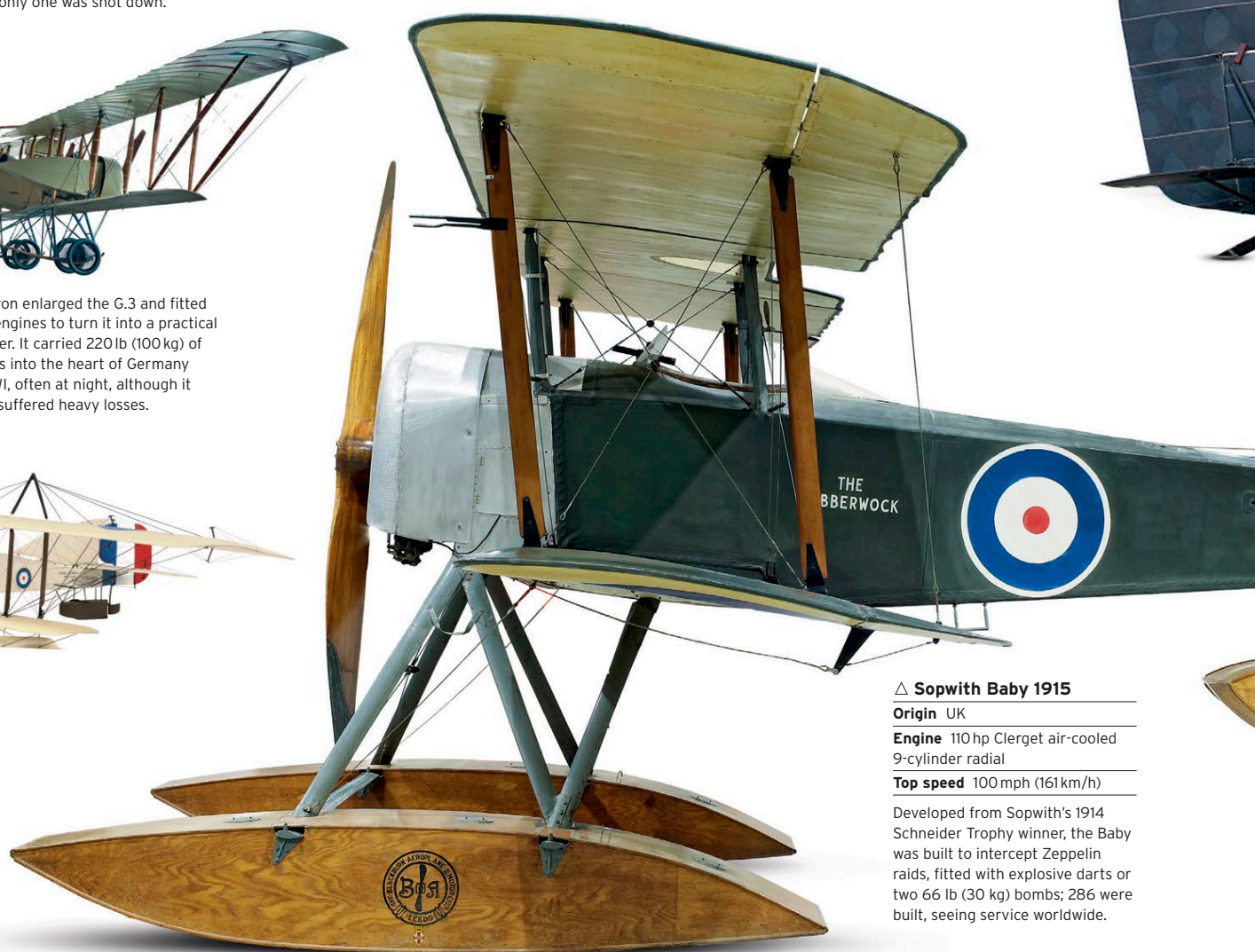
△ Short 184 1915

Origin UK

Engine 260 hp Sunbeam Maori water-cooled V12

Top speed 89 mph (132 km/h)

Designed to drop torpedos on enemy shipping, the 184 was the first—on August 12, 1915—to sink a ship with an air-launched torpedo and was the only plane to participate in the Battle of Jutland.



△ Sopwith Baby 1915

Origin UK

Engine 110 hp Clerget air-cooled 9-cylinder radial

Top speed 100 mph (161 km/h)

Developed from Sopwith's 1914 Schneider Trophy winner, the Baby was built to intercept Zeppelin raids, fitted with explosive darts or two 66 lb (30 kg) bombs; 286 were built, seeing service worldwide.